

and is naturalized in Australia. The leaves are gathered in spring and are consumed as food. The seedpods can serve as a substitute for black pepper.

Parts Used Leaves, root.

Constituents Virginia peppergrass contains high levels of vitamin C.

History & Folklore The Menominee of eastern North America applied a lotion of Virginia peppergrass (or a bruised fresh plant) to poison ivy eruptions.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Virginia peppergrass is nutritious and generally detoxifying. It has been used to treat vitamin C deficiency and diabetes, and to expel intestinal worms. The herb is also diuretic and of benefit in easing rheumatic pain. The root is taken to treat excess phlegm within the respiratory tract.

Related Species Maca (*L. meyenii*) is a low-growing Andean perennial. The root is valued as a staple food and medicine by Andean peoples, notably to support immune function and for hormonal disorders including sterility. Maca is now commonly available in supplement stores and has acquired a reputation as a tonic, hormone balancer, and aphrodisiac.

Leptandra virginica syn. *Veronicastrum virginicum* (Scrophulariaceae)

Black Root

Description Perennial herb growing to 3 ft (1 m). Has an erect stem, lance-shaped leaves, and white flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Black root grows across North America in meadows and woodlands. The root is unearthed in autumn.

Part Used Dried root.

Constituents Black root contains a volatile oil, saponins, sugars, and tannins.

History & Folklore Known to the Native Americans of Missouri and Delaware as a

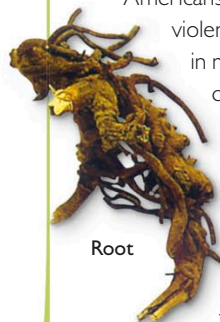
violent purgative, black root was used in moderate doses as a laxative, a detoxifier, and a remedy for liver disorders. In the 19th century Physiomedicalist tradition, black root was taken to stimulate bile production.

Medicinal Actions & Uses

Black root is used in small doses today as a laxative and a remedy for liver and gallbladder disorders.

The herb also treats flatulence and bloating, and eases the discomfort of hemorrhoids, chronic constipation, and rectal prolapse.

Cautions Do not use the fresh root. Do not take during pregnancy.



Root

Levisticum officinale syn. *Ligusticum levisticum* (Apiaceae)

Lovage

Description Perennial growing to 6½ ft (2 m).

Has glossy, toothed compound leaves, greenish-yellow flowers, and tiny oval seeds.

Habitat & Cultivation Lovage is found in southern Europe and southwestern Asia. It thrives on sunny mountain slopes. The leaves are gathered in spring or early summer; the seeds in late summer; the root in autumn.

Parts Used Root, seeds, leaves.

Constituents Lovage root contains a volatile oil (about 70% phthalides), coumarins (including bergapten, psoralen, and umbelliferone), alkynes, plant acids, sterols, resins, and gums. The phthalides are sedative and anticonvulsant.

History & Folklore The *Trotula* texts, written in Salerno during the 12th century, recommend lovage for skin lightening. The Irish herbalist K'Eogh follows this recommendation: "lovage clears the sight and removes spots, freckles and redness from the face."

Medicinal Actions & Uses Lovage is a warming and tonic herb for the digestive and respiratory systems. It treats indigestion, poor appetite, gas and colic, and bronchitis. Lovage is significantly diuretic and antimicrobial and is commonly taken for urinary tract problems. It also promotes menstruation and relieves period pain. Its warming nature improves poor circulation.

Related Species The Chinese *chuan xiong* (*Ligusticum chuanxiong*) is used principally as a means to bring on absent menstrual periods and to treat period pain. The Chinese *gao ben* (*Ligusticum sinense*) is also used for pain.

Cautions Do not take during pregnancy. Do not take if you suffer from kidney disease. Can increase sensitivity to sunlight.

Self-help Use Heavy menstrual bleeding, p. 315.

Lippia alba (Verbenaceae)

Lippia, Bushy Lippia, Prontoalivio

Description Multi-branched, square-stemmed, aromatic shrub growing to 5 ft (1.5 m), with opposite leaves and small white or pink flowers close to the leaf axils.

Habitat & Cultivation Lippia grows throughout South and Central America from northern Argentina to the southern U.S. It is a common garden herb, and may be grown from seed or cuttings, the latter being used for commercial cultivation.

Parts Used Leaves.

Constituents Lippia leaves contain about 0.15% volatile oil with different plant strains, or chemotypes, producing several essential oils with quite a distinct range of compounds, notably citral and carvone. The citral chemotype oil is thought to have strong anti-*Candida* activity.

History & Folklore In many parts of Central and South America, Lippia is valued for its ability to resolve common illnesses, such as stomach upset, nausea, gas and bloating, coughs, colds, sore throat, and headache. Its Colombian name, Prontoalivio (meaning "quick relief") points to its place in popular Latin American medicine.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Lippia has pain-relieving, anti-inflammatory, relaxant, and antispasmodic properties, making it useful in many non-severe health problems. In Brazil, where it is regulated as a medicinal herb, the herb is typically used for upper digestive problems, coughs, colds, and bronchitis, as well as for high blood pressure and as a sedative. The herb has been little researched, though a small clinical trial in Brazil found it effective in treating migraine headache. The essential oil is increasingly used in pharmaceutical and cosmetic preparations, for example, within Europe, and has significant antifungal and antibacterial activity on the skin.

Related Species The sweet tasting *L. dulcis* has broadly similar medicinal use and is found across Central America and the Caribbean. See also Lemon Verbena (*Lippia citriodora*, following entry).

Lippia citriodora syn. *Aloysia triphylla* (Verbenaceae)

Lemon Verbena

Description Deciduous shrub growing to 6½ ft (2 m). Has strongly scented lance-shaped leaves and clusters of tubular, pale green to mauve flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Lemon verbena is native to South America. It is cultivated in temperate climates as an aromatic, ornamental plant and for its leaves, which are used to make herbal tea. The leaves are gathered in late summer.

Parts Used Leaves.

Constituents Lemon verbena contains a volatile oil (mainly consisting of citral, cineole, limonene, and geraniol), mucilage, tannins, and flavonoids.

History & Folklore Lemon verbena was introduced to Europe in 1784. In Spain, France, and elsewhere in Europe, the infusion is a popular drink.

Medicinal Actions & Uses An undervalued medicinal herb, lemon verbena shares qualities with lemon balm (*Melissa officinalis*, p. 113). Both herbs contain a strong lemon-scented volatile oil that has calming and digestive properties. Lemon verbena has a gentle sedative action and a reputation for